

Introduction

By the 1700s, as the Enlightenment gained pace, the persecution of witches was waning. Legislation now stressed the prosecution of occultists for duping people with claims to false powers rather than for being agents of Satan performing mysterious magic. Such skepticism was bound to arise in the Age of Reason that the Enlightenment represented, with its emphasis on scientific inquiry and on organizing strands of thought into specialist disciplines.

However, no doubt partly as a reaction against the growing rationalization and industrialization at that time, powerful forms of occultism gained a foothold. Events that helped feed this interest included the political revolutions that were overturning old orders, from France (1780s and 1790s) to America (1775–1783). Revolution nurtured an individualistic freedom of creative expression that often veered into the wildly supernatural or macabre—as in the dark Romanticism of writer Edgar Allan Poe. Occult worlds that held

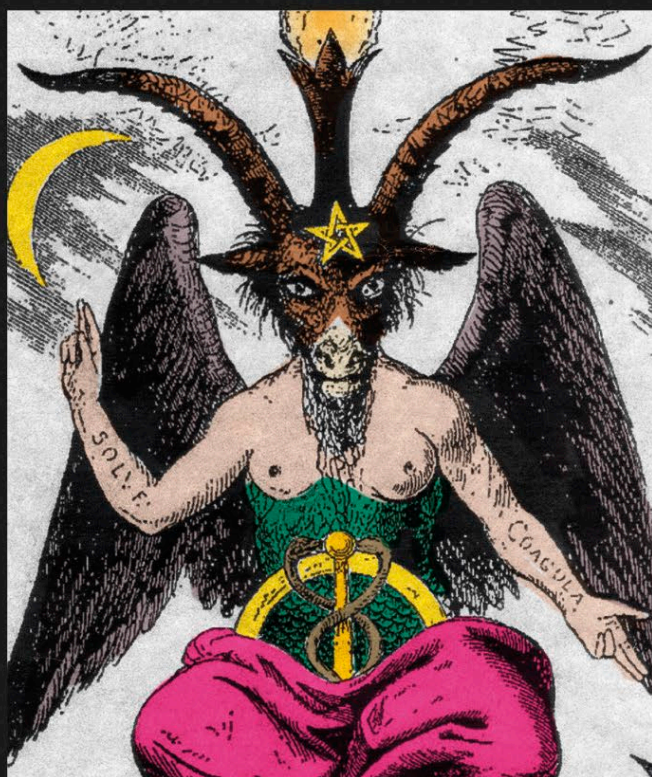
fascination in the 1800s and early 1900s included theosophy: building on mystical ideas from the Renaissance, the more modern form of the 19th century—promoted by flamboyant Russian spiritualist Helena Blavatsky—took in Western occultism, the wisdom of Indian religions, and modern science.

Theosophist ideas shared ground with those of the Rosicrucians, themselves linked with Freemasonry. In the 1700s, 1800s, and early 1900s, many secret occult societies, including the 19th-century Hermetic Order of the Golden Dawn, started up, connected with such traditions, and were steeped in ritual. Ritual was also key to Voodoo, followed in the Caribbean, in which a fertile mix of beliefs centered on the spirits of the dead.

Other seeming countercurrents to order and mechanized progress gathered momentum in the 1800s and brought with them a general craze for magic as spectacle and performance. The most



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The goat-headed Devil Baphomet see p.213



The Sun tarot card see p.218